

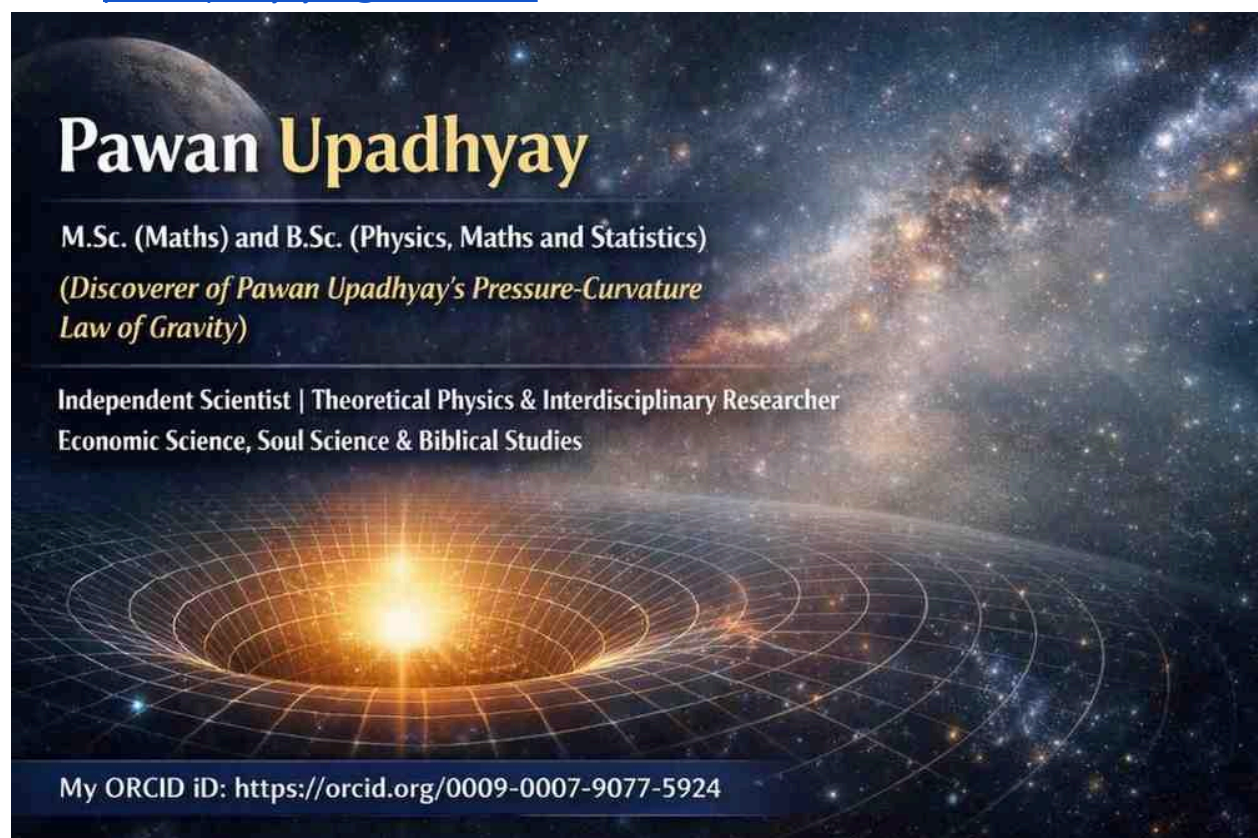
The Nature of God and Angels: Spirit, Form, and the Concept of Spiritual Appearance

Author: Pawan Upadhyay

Affiliation: Independent Researcher

ORCID iD: <https://orcid.org/0009-0007-9077-5924>

Email: pawanupadhyay28@hotmail.com



Abstract

This research paper examines the nature of God and angels with particular attention to the relationship between spirit, body, and form. It critically engages the concept of a “spiritual body,” redefining it as a *mode of appearance* rather than an ontological structure. Drawing on the Bible and theological reasoning, the paper proposes that while God and angels are pure spirit, they may manifest in human-like forms for revelatory purposes. This study reconciles scriptural descriptions with philosophical clarity by distinguishing essence from appearance.

1. Introduction

The question of whether spiritual beings possess a “body” has long generated theological debate. Scriptural narratives often describe angels—and at times God—appearing in visible, even human-like forms. This raises an important question:

Are these beings formless, or do they possess a kind of “spiritual body”?

This paper argues that the term “spiritual body” can be reinterpreted as **a visible, non-material manifestation of pure spirit**, without implying material composition.

2. The Nature of God as Pure Spirit

2.1 Biblical Foundation

The Gospel of John declares:

“God is spirit” (John 4:24)

This establishes that God is:

- non-material
- not confined to space
- beyond physical structure

2.2 Divine Transcendence and Appearance

Although God is pure spirit, scripture records instances where God **appears in perceivable forms**, particularly in the Old Testament:

- fire (burning bush)
- cloud and glory
- anthropomorphic visions

These are not God’s essence but **intentional manifestations** adapted to human perception.

3. The Image of God in Humanity

3.1 Scriptural Basis

The Book of Genesis states:

“God created man in His image” (Genesis 1:27)

3.2 Interpretive Expansion

Traditionally understood as spiritual and moral likeness, this paper expands the idea:

The human form may serve as a **symbolic or chosen mode of divine self-disclosure**, not because God has a body, but because human form is uniquely suited to reflect divine rationality and relationality.

4. The Nature of Angels

4.1 Angels as Pure Spirits

According to the Bible, angels are:

- created beings
- immaterial
- essentially spiritual

4.2 Angelic Manifestations

In the Book of Genesis and other texts, angels:

- appear as human beings
 - interact physically
 - communicate in tangible ways
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5. The Concept of “Spiritual Appearance”

5.1 Redefining “Spiritual Body”

Instead of rejecting the term entirely, this paper proposes a refined definition:

A **spiritual body** is not a body in substance, but a **visible, human-like form assumed by pure spirit for interaction and revelation**.

This avoids materiality while preserving scriptural realism.

5.2 Characteristics of Spiritual Appearance

Such manifestations:

- are **non-material**
 - have **recognizable form (often human-like)**
 - are **temporary and purposeful**
 - do not define the being's essence
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6. Application to Angels

Angels may:

- assume human-like forms
- appear as if embodied
- interact within physical environments

Thus, what appears as a “body” is better understood as:

a **projected or assumed form**, not an intrinsic structure

7. Application to God

7.1 Manifestational Appearances

God, being pure spirit, may also:

- reveal Himself in perceivable forms
- communicate through visible manifestations

7.2 Special Case: The Incarnation

Christian theology uniquely affirms that God became truly human in Jesus Christ:

- not merely appearing
- but taking on real human nature

This differs fundamentally from temporary manifestations.

8. Philosophical Clarification: Essence vs Appearance

Category	Essence	Appearance
God	Pure spirit	Manifested form (symbolic/visible)
Angels	Pure spirit	Assumed human-like form
Humans	Body + soul	Natural physical body

This distinction resolves the tension between:

- **formless essence**
 - **visible manifestation**
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9. Resolving the Debate

Statement under evaluation:

“Spiritual body is pure spirit in human shape.”

Refined conclusion:

- As **essence** → incorrect (spirit has no shape)
- As **appearance** → meaningful and defensible

Thus, the idea becomes valid when properly defined as:

spiritual appearance rather than ontological body

10. Conclusion

God and angels are fundamentally **pure spirits without material bodies**. However, both can manifest in **human-like visible forms** for communication and revelation. The term “spiritual

body,” if used, must be carefully redefined to mean **a non-material, temporary, and functional appearance**, not a true body.

This framework preserves:

- theological consistency
 - scriptural integrity
 - philosophical clarity
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References

- Bible
 - Gospel of John
 - Book of Genesis
 - Old Testament
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Research Paper 2

The Burning Bush as Angelic Manifestation: A Mediated Revelation Model

Author: Pawan Upadhyay

Affiliation: Independent Researcher

ORCID ID: <https://orcid.org/0009-0007-9077-5924>

Email: pawanupadhyay28@hotmail.com

Abstract

This section presents an interpretive model of the burning bush narrative in which the visible manifestation is understood as an angel rather than God Himself. Drawing from the Book of Exodus, this view proposes that divine revelation may occur through angelic mediation, where the form is angelic while the authority and voice remain fully divine.

1. Introduction

The account of the burning bush (Exodus 3) is one of the most significant moments of divine revelation in the Bible. However, the text presents an interpretive tension by referring both to “the angel of the Lord” and to God Himself within the same narrative. This raises the question:

Was the burning bush a direct appearance of God, or an angelic manifestation through which God spoke?

This section explores the latter interpretation.

2. Textual Basis

2.1 Dual Identification in the Narrative

The Book of Exodus states:

- “The angel of the Lord appeared to him in a flame of fire...” (Exodus 3:2)
- “God called to him from the bush...” (Exodus 3:4)

This dual description suggests:

- a **visible agent** (the angel)
- a **divine speaker** (God)

Exodus 3:2

“And the angel of the LORD appeared unto him in a flame of fire out of the midst of a bush: and he looked, and, behold, the bush burned with fire, and the bush was not consumed.”

Exodus 3:4

“And when the LORD saw that he turned aside to see, God called unto him out of the midst of the bush, and said, Moses, Moses. And he said, Here am I.”

3. The Angel as Visible Mediator

3.1 Role of Angels in Scripture

Throughout the Bible, angels function as:

- messengers
- intermediaries
- agents of divine communication

Thus, it is consistent to interpret the burning bush as:

an angelic manifestation serving as the medium of divine revelation.

3.2 Nature of the Manifestation

Within this framework:

- The **fire in the bush** represents the presence of the angel
 - The angel provides a **visible, perceivable form**
 - God remains **transcendent and unseen in essence**
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4. Divine Speech Through Angelic Agency

4.1 The Voice of God

Although the manifestation is angelic, the text attributes speech directly to God:

- “I am the God of your father...”

This can be understood as:

God speaking **through** the angel, not the angel speaking independently.

Exodus 3:6 (Douay–Rheims)

“And he said: I am the God of thy father, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob. Moses hid his face: for he durst not look at God.”

4.2 Prophetic and Mediated Communication

This model aligns with broader biblical patterns:

- God speaks through prophets
- God speaks through visions
- God speaks through angels

Thus, the burning bush becomes a **unique but consistent example of mediated revelation**.

5. Theological Implications

5.1 Preservation of Divine Transcendence

This interpretation emphasizes:

- God does not take on form
 - God remains pure spirit
 - visible forms belong to created agents
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5.2 Distinction Between Form and Authority

A key principle emerges:

Aspect		Source
Visible form		Angel
Voice and authority		God

This distinction resolves the apparent contradiction in the text.

6. Comparison with Alternative Interpretations

6.1 Direct Theophany View

Mainstream theology often holds that:

- God Himself appeared in the bush
- the “angel of the Lord” is a form of divine presence

6.2 Mediated Revelation View (This Study)

In contrast, this model maintains:

- the angel is distinct from God

- the appearance is created, not divine
 - God speaks through, but is not identical with, the manifestation
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7. Strengths of the Angelic Interpretation

- Respects the explicit mention of “angel of the Lord”
 - Maintains strict divine immateriality
 - Aligns with the broader role of angels as mediators
 - Avoids attributing form or shape to God
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8. Challenges and Considerations

- The text directly identifies the speaker as God
 - The transition from “angel” to “God” requires explanation
 - Some traditions interpret this overlap as intentional unity rather than distinction
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9. Conclusion

The burning bush narrative can be coherently understood as an **angelic manifestation through which God speaks**. In this model:

- the **appearance is angelic**
- the **message is divine**

This interpretation preserves both:

- the transcendence of God as pure spirit
 - and the scriptural realism of visible revelation
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References

- Bible
 - Book of Exodus
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